



lips pluck grass
when grazing

thin outer skin layer
can dry out quickly



Hippopotamus

Hippopotamus amphibius

Although its name means “river horse,” the hippopotamus, or hippo, more closely resembles the pig. In addition to similar teeth patterns, the two animals belong to the order artiodactyls—even-toed hoofed mammals. However, the hippopotamus’s closest living relatives are not land mammals but whales and dolphins, with which it shared a common ancestor millions of years ago.

The hippopotamus is nearly hairless, and has an enormous mouth with teeth to match. Its bulky, barrel-shaped body makes it the Earth’s third largest land animal, after elephants and rhinoceroses. Adult males weigh an average of 3,300lb (1,500kg) while females average 2,900lb (1,300kg). Despite its size and short, stocky legs, a hippo can sprint up to 18mph (30km/h). Speed, natural aggression, and 16–20-in- (40–50-cm-) long canine and incisor teeth that grow and sharpen themselves continuously make hippos one of Africa’s most unpredictably dangerous species. They kill more people in Africa each year than any other mammal.

Walking underwater

As a semiaquatic animal, the hippopotamus spends its days in rivers, lakes, and swamps, where water and mud keep it cool and cover its skin in vital moisture. Water also supports its weight, and the animal can easily trundle or even leap along a lake bottom at speeds of up to 5mph (8km/h). However, even though a hippopotamus has webbed feet, it is

not a strong swimmer; it cannot even float, so it stays in the shallows, closing its nostrils as it submerges, surfacing every 3–5 minutes to breathe.

Night grazer

Hippos feed at dusk, moving inland up to 6 miles (10km) in search of the short grass that makes up the bulk of their diet. Adults consume as much as 150lb (70kg) of grass each night, pulling it up with their lips before crushing it with their large, grinding molars. The massive canines and incisors are only used in fighting and defense. Hippos “yawn” when threatened to show these teeth to their best advantage, opening their mouths nearly 180 degrees. Males defend territories by day, and it is thought that “dung-spinning”—performed mainly by males wagging their tails when defecating—is done partially as a territorial marking activity.

Mother and calf

Females can breed all year round, but most mating occurs in the dry season. Mating takes place in the water, with the female staying submerged for most of the process. A single calf, weighing up to 110lb (50kg), is born underwater and has to swim or be helped to the surface for its first breath. Baby hippopotamuses have sterile intestines, and must eat their mother’s dung in order to obtain the bacteria they need for digesting grass. Juveniles are vulnerable to attacks by crocodiles, lions, and spotted hyenas.



△ BABY HIPPO

Calves are born and suckle underwater. They often ride on their mother’s back if the water is too deep.

Hippo calls can reach up to **115 decibels**—as loud as close-range thunder